

states KERALA

IRON MAN'S COUNTRY



The unearthing of pre-historic artefacts in an obscure village shows trade flourished here as far back as 3,500 years ago

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

Pattanam, a sleepy hamlet on the banks of the river Periyar does not show up on the map of central Kerala, but there is evidence now that this tiny village once had maritime contacts with far-off lands in the 1st century A.D. Research, done in February-March 2007, reveals that this village, 25 km north of Kochi, was a busy, international hinterland port town and had an Indo-Roman settlement. The recovered artefacts hint at Pattanam having an urban habitation since the Iron Age dating to 1500 B.C. Accelerator Mass Spectrometry radio carbon analysis done by Bhubaneswar's Institute of Physics of the charcoal samples, remnants of a wooden canoe and bollard has established the town's pre-historic antiquity. Besides the sand layers and megalithic pottery, excavated material includes pieces of Roman amphora (wine jar), rouletted ware, Parthian-Sassanian pottery, West Asian ceramics, glass beads, semi-precious stones, chera copper coins and Roman golden

HISTORIC FIND: Brick platform and a terracotta ring well (top); artist's impression of settlement

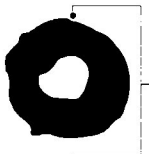
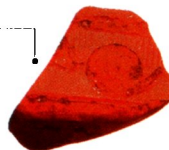


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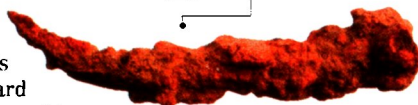
The well-crafted artefacts have led archaeologists to believe that Pattanam was the intelligent Iron Age man's Indo-Roman "urban" settlement

TERRA SIGILLATA:

A shred of earthenware made out of reddish-brown clay



FERROUS: Iron objects, like nails and slags, were found in large numbers



ROMAN AMPHORA:

264 pieces of amphora, like wine jars, were gathered from a 123 sq ft trench



rings dating between 1st century B.C. and 5th century A.D. "It's the first habitation site of the Iron Age unearthed in the Malabar Coast. The excavations mark a breakthrough," says P.J. Cherian, director, Kerala Council of Historical Research (KCHR), which led the two-month-long exercise.

It was in 2004, that Pattanam first caught the attention of archaeologists. They were trying to trace Muziris, a legendary port mentioned in many ancient literary pieces and travelogues. Trial excavations and surface surveys by local archaeologists provided preliminary understanding of the site as the Iron Age wares and shreds were recovered from homesteads and school grounds. This led to the launch of a multi-disciplinary and archaeological study as a part of the Muziris

